possessions (beyond *artha* which is the legitimate acquisition of wealth and worldly goods for a worthy life). Four other vices are personal failings that are within an individual's capacity to prevent: *krodha* (hatred), *mada* (vanity), *matsarya* (envy) and *moha* (delusion arising from ignorance or infatuation). These six obstacles are prevented and overcome through the practice of seven essential virtues laid down from the time of Adi Shankara: *ahimsa* (non-violence), *satyam* (truth), *shivam* (piety), *sundaram* (the cultivation of beauty), *vairagyam* (detachment), *pavitram* (purity) and *swabhavam* (self-control). The rejection of these vices and the practice of these virtues are essential for a Hindu to lead a good life.

My boss wanted a more pragmatic reason for why a Hindu should be good. If it was not the promise of a better life in the next world, or a desire to avoid eternal damnation in Hell, what was a Hindu's incentive? I explained that whereas in Christianity the body has a soul, in Hinduism the soul has a body. In other words, we are emanations of a universal soul, the *atman*, which does not die; it discards its temporal form, the body, from time to time. Since the purpose of the soul is ultimately to reach moksha, to attain union with Brahman and stop the endless cycle of birth and rebirth in various bodies, the incentive for a Hindu to be good lay in the desire to progress towards this goal. An amoral Hindu, one who lived in *adharma*, would be in disharmony with the world and be set back in his soul's striving for *moksha*.

I am not sure he was satisfied with my answer, and I am not sure you, the reader, will be. There was, however, a catch in what I was propounding. If the soul is permanent and the body is not, it makes sense that the soul sheds bodies and keeps returning to earth until it has attained *moksha*; from this flows the doctrine of *punarjanmam* (reincarnation), the idea that one will be reborn until one has attained that level of self-realisation.

The idea of reincarnation, emerging from the endless cycle of birth and rebirth, is basic to Hinduism. If in other faiths the individual is a body which has its own soul, in Hinduism the individual is a soul which happens to be in temporary possession of a certain body; the immortal soul occupies a mortal corpus, which it discards at the end of its physical